

AI data centers are forcing dirty 'peaker' power plants back into service

Posted by u/EchoOfOppenheimer • 0 points • 1 comments

The AI boom is officially reversing the green energy transition. A new Reuters investigation reveals that skyrocketing electricity demand from data centers is forcing the U.S. grid to resurrect obsolete peaker power plants-inefficient, 1960s-era fossil fuel units that were scheduled for demolition. In places like Chicago's Pilsen neighborhood, these dirty facilities are being kept online to prevent blackouts, concentrating pollution in low-income communities just to keep the servers running.

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u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2026-03-04 21:28 UTC

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u/ClimateResilient • 3 points • 2026-01-23 23:32 UTC

We want renewables to replace fossil fuels, but that's extremely difficult when growth in energy demand outpaces our ability to build renewable infrastructure. Renewables require a ton of metals, and the pace of expansion is often [bottlenecked by mining](<https://news.umich.edu/copper-cant-be-mined-fast-enough-to-electrify-the-us/>) (mostly the permitting process, which is valid as the ecological impacts aren't minor).

Despite big growth in the renewables sector, we're burning [far more coal, oil, and natural gas] (<https://ourworldindata.org/grapher/global-energy-substitution>) than we were 5 years ago. As long as energy demand outpaces growth in renewable infrastructure, this will continue to be the case. A sustainable future requires changing our energy sources *and* lowering total energy consumption; AI isn't helping with either.

There's no solution to the climate crisis that doesn't involve pumping the brakes on unchecked growth.